This new state of affairs has led to a step-change in Rakhine state. Over the past year, a new actor emerged on the scene in this already complex and intractable conflict: the Arakan Rohingya Salvation Army (ARSA). They first appeared on the scene in October 2016 when they attacked three police outposts in the Maungdaw and Rathedaung townships, killing nine police officers. Since then, they have carried out more attacks in August 2017 and their actions have been the trigger for the recent wave of ethnic cleansing by the Myanmar military. While the group is small, probably no more than a few hundred fighters, it has already acted as a catalyst for more localised acts of resistance, as some Rohingya men try to defend their communities. In turn, of course, the emergence of such a group has led to predictable claims by the NLD and the Myanmar military that they are facing attacks by people with links to Al-Qaeda or Islamic State.

While the claims that Muslims in Myanmar have a ‘jihadist’ agenda have been a common part of the military and extremist Buddhist narrative about the Rohingyas, the reality is that apart from a brief uprising in 1946–7, the Rohingyas have been entirely peaceful in the face of persecution. While most other ethnic minority groups have had a long history of armed resistance to the Burmese state, the Rohingyas have opted to remain peaceful. They have fought back on a localised basis, such as during the ethnic conflicts of 2012, but this has not coalesced into a structured resistance.

But now, in the wake of the most brutal crackdown the military has ever undertaken against the Rohingyas and the rise of ARSA, there is a genuine worry that Al-Qaeda or IS might manage to insert themselves into the situation. For example, IS has recently started to mention the Rohingyas in its propaganda broadcasts and Indonesian authorities report they have thwarted two plots to blow up the Myanmar embassy in Jakarta.

This concern also extends beyond the Rohingyas in Myanmar. The treatment of the Rohingya refugees who fled to India and to Bangladesh is also hugely problematic. There has been some evidence of terrorist groups linked to the conflict in Kashmir trying to make connections with the Rohingyas in India. Some quarters in the Indian government, led by the Hindu-nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), have called for an end to sanctuary for Rohingya refugees, and for the deportation of those Rohingyas already in the country back into the hands of the Myanmar army. Denied official status even as refugees, and therefore any of the protections